

ASCENDANT IMPACT

A cinematic one-versus-one supernatural fighting game

AUTHOR
Anthony T.

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ENGINE / PLATFORM
Unreal Engine 5.8 / PC

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Executive Summary

HIGH CONCEPT

A precision-focused fighter battles a powerful AI-controlled rival in a short third-person duel. Perfect dodges, counters, and combo milestones trigger seamless anime-inspired cinematic bursts, building toward one final clash.

Capstone scope. The long-term vision is a character-driven fighting game with multiple styles and competitive player-versus-player play. This first release deliberately focuses on one player versus one AI rival so the core combat, animation, camera rhythm, effects, and full win/lose loop can be finished and polished.

GENRE	PLAYER MODE	TARGET SESSION	ARENA
Third-person action fighter	1 player vs. AI rival	3-5 minutes	The Shattered Ring

Design pillars

1 Skill Creates Spectacle The player earns the most cinematic moments through readable timing and successful decisions.	2 Cinematic Rhythm Camera, slow motion, impact frames, and effects punctuate combat without taking control away for long.	3 Character-Driven Style Movement and choreography express personality: precision and flow versus weight and force.
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Game Mechanics

Player-facing actions, combat rhythm, cinematic rewards, and encounter structure.

Core loop

1 READ Watch the rival's telegraph.	2 RESPOND Attack, dodge, or counter.	3 BUILD Gain Ascension energy.	4 IMPACT Earn a timing window.	5 ESCALATE Enter the next phase.	6 CLASH Resolve the final exchange.
PLAYER FIGHTER - AGENT ECHO (PROXY) - Precision striker: lean, fast, and fists-first. - Full-face black visor and simple black/charcoal suit with orange accents reduce early face and hair production. - Controller-first actions: move, light combo, dodge, perfect dodge, and counter.			AI RIVAL - AGENT NOVA (PROXY) - Agile pressure rival in the same visual design family. - Four authored attacks with readable anticipation, active, and recovery timing. - Two phases: controlled testing first, faster power escalation second.		

Cinematic Impact System

SIGNATURE MECHANIC A meaningful combat event can open a short Impact Window. The camera pushes to a dramatic angle, time briefly compresses, and a timing prompt appears. Success extends the current exchange into a 1-3 second choreographed burst before control returns immediately to normal combat.		
MECHANIC	PLAYER EXPERIENCE	PROTOTYPE RULE
Perfect Dodge	Brief time compression and positional advantage.	Tight timing near impact; no cinematic every time.
Counter	A forceful reversal with stronger meter gain.	Available after a perfect dodge or clear recovery opening.
Impact Window	One fast timing input can extend a combo.	Authored triggers plus cooldown prevent repetition.
Ascension Meter	Visible progress toward the climax.	Built by skillful play; not passive waiting.
Final Clash	Largest camera and effects sequence in the encounter.	Two timing beats; success ends the duel, failure returns to combat.

Encounter flow and outcomes

Opening: 5-8 second entrance, rival reveal, then immediate player control. **Phase 1:** learn readable attacks and earn the first Impact Window. **Phase 2:** faster pressure, stronger effects, and visual arena damage. **Climax:** the Final Clash becomes available near the rival's defeat threshold.

WIN CONDITION Complete the Final Clash and defeat Agent Nova.	LOSS CONDITION Agent Echo's health reaches zero.
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AI Architecture

Specialized development agents support the build; the shipped prototype does not require runtime generative-AI calls.

ARCHITECTURE PRINCIPLE

One agent, one focused responsibility. Every output is reviewed by Anthony before it changes the Unreal project. Agents help plan, implement, document, and test; human judgment owns creative taste and final approval.

Development agent crew

AGENT	FOCUSED INPUT	STRUCTURED OUTPUT	PLAYER-FACING EFFECT
Scope Producer	Current GDD and proposed feature.	Keep / cut / defer decision with reason.	Protects a complete, polished duel instead of an unfinished feature pile.
Combat Design	Move list, phase goals, timing values.	Readable attack table with anticipation, active, recovery, and meter rewards.	Creates fair openings for dodges, counters, and escalation.
Unreal Blueprint	One approved gameplay task plus project context.	Blueprint plan, node-level steps, acceptance test, and rollback note.	Turns the approved design into working player actions and rival behavior.
Cinematic Beat	Trigger condition, animation clips, desired emotion.	Shot spec: lens, camera move, duration, timing prompt, VFX, and return-to-play frame.	Makes impact moments feel fluid, brief, and character-specific.
Animation Integration	Animation assets and combat state map.	Montage sections, notifies, hit frames, transitions, and asset gaps.	Keeps attacks responsive and synchronizes damage, sound, camera, and effects.
QA Stress Test	GDD, build notes, known bugs, and test checklist.	Edge cases, reproduction steps, severity, and pass/fail criteria.	Prevents stuck states, unfair damage, repeated cinematics, and broken win/loss flow.

AI-assisted development pipeline

01	DEFINE	Anthony approves the mechanic, intended player feeling, and definition of done.
02	SPECIFY	The relevant specialist agent turns the idea into a small structured task.
03	IMPLEMENT	The Unreal Blueprint or Animation Integration agent proposes the build steps.
04	VERIFY	The change is tested in Play-in-Editor against explicit acceptance criteria.
05	REVIEW	QA and Scope agents identify failures; Anthony accepts, revises, or rejects the result.

Human gates

- Creative direction: choreography, character personality, camera taste, and what feels exciting.
- Asset approval: animation, audio, VFX, and licensing decisions.
- Technical approval: every agent-proposed project change is tested before it is retained.
- Fun validation: real people must play the build; agents can find logic gaps but cannot certify fun.

Runtime AI boundary

Agent Nova is controlled by authored NPC combat AI inside Unreal Engine 5.8, using an AI Controller and a compact state machine or Behavior Tree. No large-language-model request is required while the player is fighting. This keeps response time predictable, removes runtime token cost, and allows the packaged game to work offline.

Technical Strategy

Build plan, constraints, token budget, API limits, and definition of done.

Implementation target - Unreal Engine 5.8

Development workflow. Unreal MCP will be used as an experimental, local editor-assistance layer for small, reviewable tasks such as selected actor setup, lighting and material adjustments, asset inspection, and automation tests. MCP supports development; it does not control the shipped combat runtime.

STARTING POINT Unreal Engine 5.8 Blueprint Third Person template	INPUT Enhanced Input; controller first	COMBAT ANIMATION Animation Montages + notifies	RIVAL AI AI Controller + compact authored states
CINEMATICS Gameplay camera blends; Sequencer only when needed	EFFECTS Niagara, camera shake, hit stop, sound cues	DATA Small Blueprint structs / data tables	BUILD Windows development build; offline play
UNREAL MCP Experimental local editor connection for MCP-compatible assistants.	MCP TASK SCOPE Selected assets/actors; small reversible actions with explicit acceptance tests.	RUNTIME NPC AI AI Controller + authored states / Behavior Tree; no LLM calls during play.	VERIFICATION Version control, checkpoints, Play-in-Editor tests, and human approval.

Primary constraints and mitigations

CONSTRAINT	WHY IT MATTERS	MITIGATION
Combat polish	Responsive third-person fighting and clean animation transitions are the largest schedule risk.	One hero, one rival, one arena, one light combo, one dodge, one counter.
Cinematic flow	Camera cuts can feel jarring or become repetitive.	Use short authored shot patterns, trigger cooldowns, fixed screen direction, and fast return to gameplay.
Asset availability	The exact choreography may exceed available animation clips.	Choose the animation set early; design moves around confirmed assets; identify human-created gaps.
AI output reliability	Agent advice can be inconsistent or overly agreeable.	Use narrow tasks, structured outputs, versioned prompts, human approval, and playtesting.
Experimental Unreal MCP	The UE 5.8 MCP feature is still evolving and agent actions can be incomplete or incorrect.	Keep it local and editor-only; use narrow tasks, version control, checkpoints, and manual PIE verification.

Token budget and API constraints

WORKSTREAM	SOFT CAP	BUDGET RULE
GDD, architecture, and task specs	40,000 tokens	Use concise context packages and approved templates.
Blueprint, Unreal MCP, and debugging	140,000 tokens	One mechanic per session; include only relevant files/screenshots.
Animation, camera, and VFX specifications	60,000 tokens	Reuse a fixed cinematic-beat output contract.
QA, red-team review, and revisions	60,000 tokens	Run focused reviews at milestones, not after every tiny edit.
TOTAL CAPSTONE ESTIMATE	300,000 tokens	Soft cap; log major sessions and reduce context when outputs drift.

API constraints: The packaged prototype contains no runtime LLM/API dependency. Unreal MCP is used only as a local, experimental editor-development bridge. External development agents remain subject to context, token, and rate limits; any paid API experiment requires an explicit cap. Agent context is limited to the current task, selected Unreal assets or actors, the relevant GDD section, and the minimum project material needed to complete that task.

Definition of done

CAPSTONE MUST SHIP

- Complete start-to-finish duel with win and loss screens.
- Move, light combo, dodge, perfect dodge, and counter.
- Two rival phases and at least three authored Impact moments.
- Ascension Meter and one recoverable Final Clash.
- Packaged PC build tested by at least three people.

OUT OF SCOPE / STRETCH

- Local PvP is a stretch goal only after the AI duel works.
- Online multiplayer, matchmaking, and replication.
- Multiple arenas, campaign levels, loot, and skill trees.
- Large roster or multiple full combat styles.
- Runtime generative dialogue or AI-controlled choreography.

Technical note: Unreal MCP is an Experimental Unreal Engine 5.8 editor feature. It is used for development assistance only; the rival NPC remains authored and offline at runtime.

NORTH STAR: Finish one cinematic duel that feels good, looks memorable, and creates a foundation that can be expanded later.

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Early Visual Direction

The current visuals are practical proxy targets for the first prototype. They establish silhouette, color blocking, presentation rhythm, and Unreal build scope without locking final character art.



Agent Echo - player proxy

Lean masked precision striker in a simple matte-black/charcoal suit with lit-orange accents. The full-face visor avoids early face and hair production so the prototype can prioritize combat, animation, camera, and effects.

Agent Nova - rival proxy

Agile AI rival proxy in the same visual family: cropped orange vest, black/charcoal technical suit, thigh pouch, knee armor, and full-face helmet. She may later become an alternate playable fighter.

Target combat presentation



COMBAT LANGUAGE

Readable third-person combat gains brief low-angle pushes, orange motion arcs, debris, hit-stop, and cinematic lighting during earned Impact Windows and the Final Clash.

CONCEPT VISUALIZATION NOT CAPTURED GAMEPLAY

This video shows the target direction for character presentation, loadout selection, arena materialization, cinematic run-in, combat escalation, camera movement, lighting, impact effects, and the final pose.

[Watch Concept Visualization](#)

Visual status: early proxy direction. These designs and shots may change after animation tests, Unreal implementation, and gameplay feedback.